Although the Rig Veda is concerned mostly with religion, the hymns do mention one event that is almost certainly historical. This is often called the ‘Battle of the Ten Kings’ that occurred on the banks of the Ravi river in Punjab. [24] It appears that ten powerful tribes ganged up against the Bharata tribe and its chieftain Sudasa. [25] The confederacy appears to have mainly consisted of tribes from what is now western Punjab and the North West Frontier Province (both now in Pakistan). In contrast, the Bharatas were an ‘eastern’ tribe from what is now Haryana. [26] Despite the odds, the Bharatas crushed the confederacy in the battle. There are descriptions of how the defeated warriors fled the battlefield or were drowned in the Ravi.

As I stand on the edge of the Ghaggar river in Haryana, I imagine the Bharata tribesmen fording the river on their way to the great battle. As described in the Rig Veda, the warriors would have been dressed in white robes, each with his long hair tied in a knot on his head. There would have been horses neighing, bronze weapons shining in the sun and perhaps the rhythmic sound of sage Vashishtha’s disciples chanting hymns to the gods. The Saraswati was a sizeable river then, not the stream that I see before me. Perhaps there would have been rafts ferrying men and supplies across the river. As I stand watching the river, a few soldiers from the nearby army camp wade knee-deep through the Ghaggar. They are Sikh soldiers, their hair knotted on top of their heads. There are no Vedic chants, but there is the soft rhythm of a diesel water-pump running in a farm somewhere.

So, how did the Bharatas single-handedly defeat the great confederacy? The political acumen and military tactics of Sudasa and his guru Vashishtha must have played a role. However, it is possible that it also had something to do with access to superior weapons, since the territory of the Bharatas included India’s best copper mines. Even today, the country’s largest copper mine is situated at Khetri along the Rajasthan–Haryana border. Armed with superior bronze and an energetic leadership, the Bharatas were a formidable force. A number of ancient ‘copper hoards’, some including weapons, have been discovered in recent decades in southern Haryana, northern Rajasthan and western Uttar Pradesh, and probably belong to this period.